

Posted High, Valued the Same

A Street-Corner Little Free Library’s Take-vs-Leave Ratio Against Neighbours’ Own Rating of the Box

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Background

Little free libraries increasingly post a running take-versus-leave ratio, offered as evidence of neighbourhood reciprocity. Whether that number tracks anything a user actually feels about the box, rather than whether anyone reads the placard at all, has not been tested.

Aims

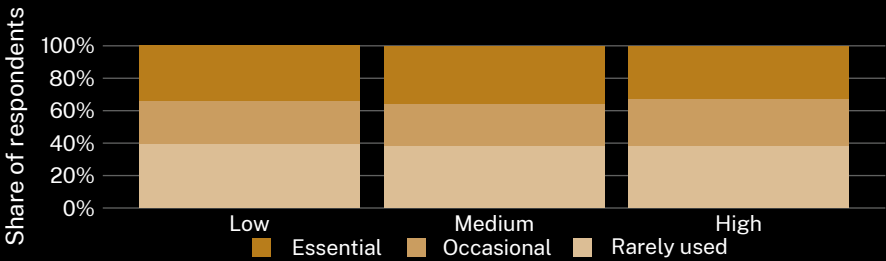
- Test whether a box’s posted ratio predicts users’ own rating of its value
- Compare rating composition across low, medium, and high ratio bands
- Isolate placard legibility as an alternative driver of any association

Methods

- n = 214 registered users · 38 suburban boxes · 14-week intercept window
- Five-point value rating matched to each box’s live posted ratio at time of survey
- Placard distance and weathering held as a covariate; ratio bands pre-registered

Results

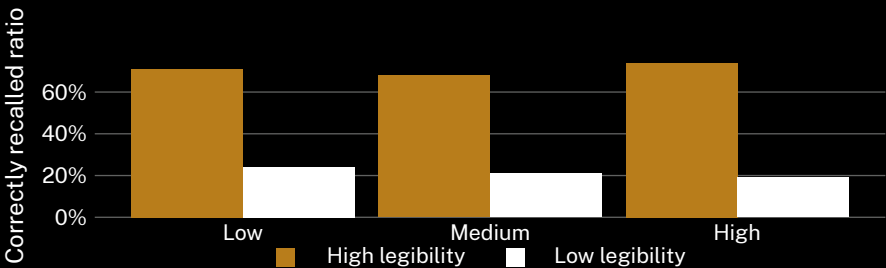
Rating composition holds near-identical across ratio bands. Placard legibility, not the ratio itself, predicts whether a user could recall the number at all.



Value-rating composition by posted ratio band, 214 respondents across 38 boxes, March–June 2026; the essential-to-rarely-used split shifts by no more than 3 points between bands.

Discussion & conclusions

The ratio reads as a health score for the box; it predicts nothing about how a neighbour actually values it, and the composition split barely shifts whether the number posted is generous or stingy. What moves the needle instead is whether a passer-by can actually read the placard from the footpath — a plainer, more structural effect than the reciprocity story the ratio is meant to tell. Next: trial a placard redesign with the ratio itself withheld, to see whether legibility alone recovers the same recall gap.



Share of respondents correctly recalling the posted ratio, by placard legibility and ratio band: legibility separates the two groups by 45–53 points in every band; the band itself separates nothing.

References

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We thank the stewards of the surveyed boxes for tolerating a clipboard on their nature strip.

De-identified survey responses only; no resident’s take/leave activity individually logged.